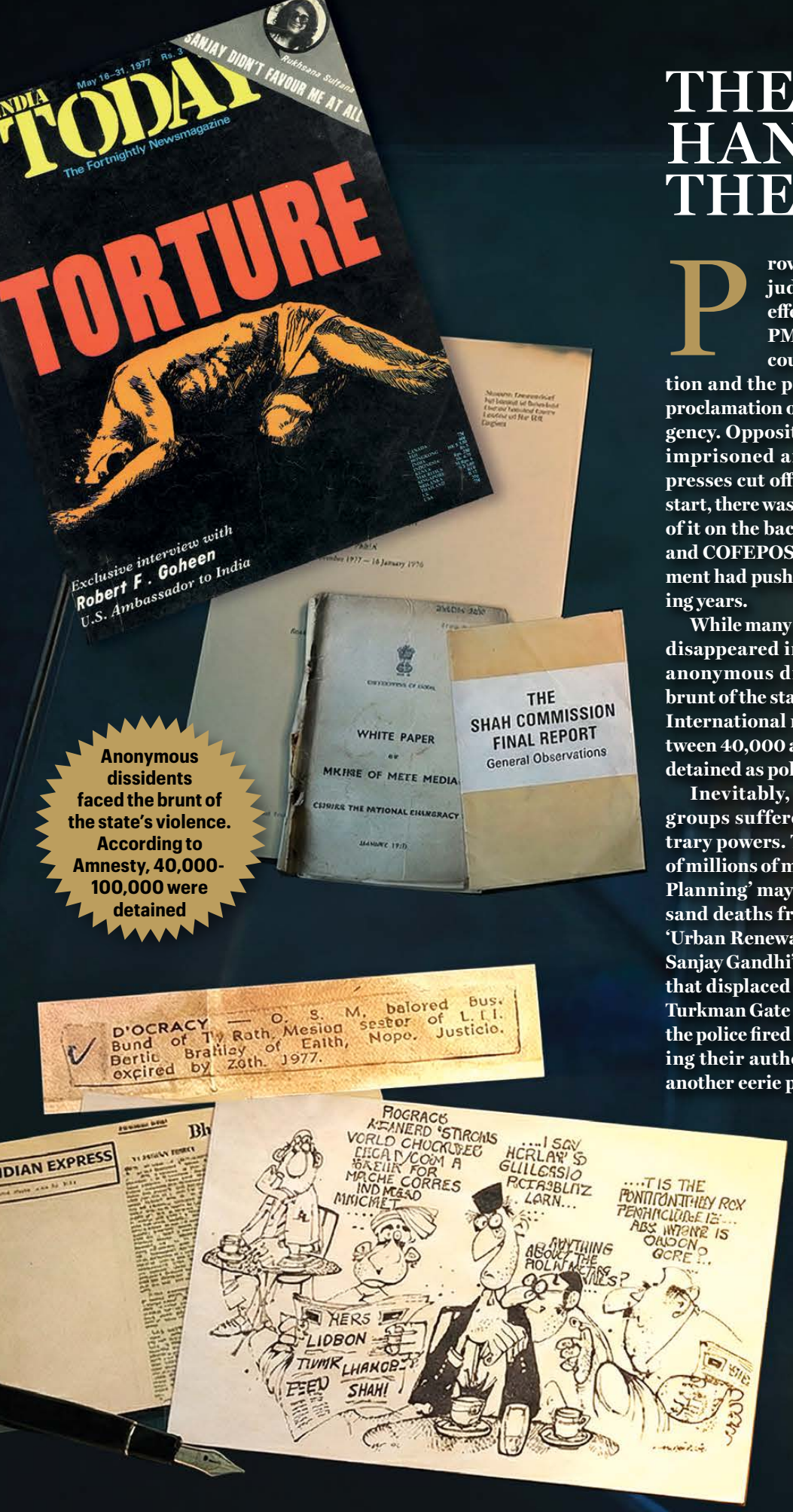
THE HEAVY HAND OF THE STATE

Provoked by an adverse court judgment that would have effectively unseated her, the PM sought to neutralise the courts, the political opposition and the press at a stroke with the proclamation of a state of national emergency. Opposition leaders were swiftly imprisoned and power to newspaper presses cut off. While this was a brutal start, there was worse to come—and much of it on the back of the draconian MISA and COFEPOSA ordinances the government had pushed through in the preceding years.

While many famous opposition figures disappeared into custody, it was more anonymous dissidents who faced the brunt of the state's violence. An Amnesty International report estimated that between 40,000 and 100,000 citizens were detained as political prisoners.

Inevitably, poor and marginalised groups suffered from the state's arbitrary powers. The forcible sterilisation of millions of men in the name of 'Family Planning' may have caused over a thousand deaths from botched procedures. 'Urban Renewal', another enthusiasm of Sanjay Gandhi's, led to demolition drives that displaced thousands. In the bloody Turkman Gate incident in Delhi, in 1976, the police fired on civilians before stamping their authority with bulldozers, in another eerie preview of the 'excesses' of later eras.

The clampdown on the press prevented effective reporting on such tragedies at the time, though they would be examined with crusading zeal by journalists and commissions of enquiry once freedoms were restored. But it was during the Emergency that the political class learned to use access to advertising to control editorial expression. ■



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